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Watchtower, tower

3.13.3.3 Watchtower, tower

References:

Hebrew אַלְמָן (’alman) ISA 13:22

Hebrew בַּחַן (bachan) ISA 32:14

Hebrew מִגְדָּל, מִגְדֹּל (migdal, migdol) JDG 8:9, JDG 8:17, JDG 9:51, JDG 9:51, JDG 9:52, JDG 9:52, 2KI 9:17, 2KI 17:9, 2KI 18:8, 1CH 27:25, 2CH 14:6, 2CH 26:9, 2CH 26:15, 2CH 27:4, 2CH 32:5, NEH 3:1, NEH 3:1, NEH 3:11, NEH 3:25, NEH 3:26, NEH 3:27, NEH 12:38, NEH 12:39, NEH 12:39, PSA 48:13, PSA 61:4, PRO 18:10, SNG 4:4, SNG 5:13, SNG 7:5, SNG 7:5, SNG 8:10, ISA 2:15, ISA 30:25, ISA 33:18, JER 31:38, EZK 26:4, EZK 26:9, EZK 27:11, ZEC 14:10

Hebrew מָצוֹר (matsor) HAB 2:1

Hebrew מִצְפֶּה (mitspeh) ISA 21:8, 2CH 20:24

Hebrew פִּנָּה (pinah) 2CH 26:15, ZEP 1:16, ZEP 3:6

Hebrew שֶׁמֶשׁ (shemesh) ISA 54:12

Greek πύργος (purgos) MAT 21:33, MRK 12:1, LUK 13:4, LUK 14:28, TOB 13:14, TOB 13:17, JDT 1:3, JDT 1:14, JDT 7:5, JDT 7:32, 1MA 1:33, 1MA 4:60, 1MA 5:5, 1MA 5:5, 1MA 5:65, 1MA 13:33, 1MA 13:43, 1MA 16:10, 2MA 10:18, 2MA 10:20, 2MA 10:22, 2MA 10:36, 2MA 13:5, 2MA 14:41, 3MA 2:27, 4MA 13:6, 1ES 1:52, 1ES 4:4

Greek σκοπή (skopē) SIR 37:14

Description:

Model of a watchtower in a city wall (© Ray Pritz by United Bible Societies)The watchtower was a tall structure with a lookout at the top.

Usage:

Watchtowers were placed at intervals along city walls to watch for an approaching enemy. They also allowed the defenders of the city to shoot at an attacker from his flank. Sometimes towers were built on private property to protect it. See also 2.19.3 Firing platform, siege tower<REALIA:2.19.3>.

Translation:

In a number of languages the expression for “tower” is simply “high building” (though of course not a skyscraper). In other instances it may be more appropriately rendered “high platform” or “high lookout place.”

The Hebrew word *’alman* in ISA 13:22 means literally “his widows.” It is very similar to a word meaning “palace” (see *’armon* under 3.4 Palace<REALIA:3.4>). It is not clear if there is a textual corruption here or if the author has deliberately interchanged the letters in order to suggest “desolation” (see de Waard, *A Handbook on Isaiah*, page 61).

2CH 20:24: While some translations (for example, NRSV, GNT, CEV) translate the Hebrew word *mitspeh* as "tower" or "watchtower," it is just as likely that the *mitspeh* was simply a high natural point from which a person had a good view. So where RSV has "the watchtower of the wilderness," NIV says "the place that overlooks the desert," NCV renders "a place where they could see the desert," and ITCL has "a hill from which it was possible to see the desert."

The Hebrew word *pinah* is literally "corner." In the references given the word may not necessarily mean a distinct structure but rather just a corner of the city wall. In ZEP 1:16 some translations have "corner towers" (NIV, NJPSV), while others are more general with "lofty battlements" (RSV; similarly NLT).

Some older translations (for example, KJV) rendered the Hebrew word *tsafith* as "watchtower" in ISA 21:5. It is now commonly accepted that it means "carpet" (see 5.17 Carpet, rug<REALIA:5.17>).

In the New Testament the Greek word *purgos* may designate any type of tower, whether employed for military purposes or used by watchmen protecting a harvest (see 1.1.11 Watchtower<REALIA:1.1.11>). In LUK 13:4 the tower was probably part of the ancient walls of Jerusalem.